THE ELECTION OF 1980:

Development of the Conservative Evangelical Voting Bloc

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The presidential election of 1980 was a watershed event in American political history. For the first time, a clear majority of American evangelicals voted for a single candidate. Ronald Reagan of the Republican party defeated Jimmy Carter of the Democratic party in a large electoral victory of 489 to 49 electoral votes.[1] Reagan's victory was decisive, winning 50.8% of the popular vote, nearly 10% more than Carter.

Reagan's large margin of victory over Carter was due largely to his campaign's unprecedented success in unifying and mobilizing the powerful evangelical voting bloc for the conservative cause. Both Reagan and Carter were born-again evangelical Christians, but Carter had more support from evangelical voters according to an earlier Gallup poll report, so, Reagan's ability to court the evangelical vote was unexpected.[2] This research paper will analyze the role of the evangelical vote in the election of 1980 and examine the political strategies that the Reagan campaign used to attract evangelical voters. Lastly, this paper will discuss the lasting implications on American politics that have come from Reagan's evangelical right.

Background

Since this paper is an analysis of the evangelical Christian voting bloc, it is essential to define what "evangelical Christian" means. Contemporary scholars attest to Devid Bebbington's "quadrilateral" definition of an evangelical Christian: biblicism, conversionism, crucicentrism, and activism.[3] "Biblicism" refers to the belief that the Bible is the supreme religious authority. "Conversionism" refers to the emphasis on rebirth (hence born-again Christians). "Crucicentrism" refers to the centrality of Jesus' crucifixion and resurrection. "Activism" refers

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[1] "United States Presidential Election of 1980 | United States Government | Britannica," accessed December 3, 2022, https://www.britannica.com/event/United-States-presidential-election-of-1980.
[2] "Dissatisfaction Motivated Voters," The Gallup Poll Index (December 1980), Report No. 183, 4.
[3] Bebbington, David. *Evangelicalism in Modern Britain: A History from the 1730s to the 1980s*. London ; Boston: Unwin Hyman, 1989.

to the aim of converting others to evangelical Christianity. The evangelical focus on activism creates a passion for involvement in the political process.

Another important facet to analyze is the difference in the rules of electoral politics in 1980 compared to today, 2022. The FECA campaign legislation of 1971 was in full effect for the election of 1980. The FECA legislation outlined that each major party nominee (both Reagan and Carter) would receive $29.4 million from the Federal Election Commission for their campaign and were not allowed to spend any other money.[4] This limit on campaign spending led to an increased importance of outside civil society groups such as PACs (political action committees) for advertisement and political messaging.

Election Overview

In 1980 Republican Ronald Reagan and his running mate George H.W. Bush beat Democrat Jimmy Carter and his running mate Bob Dole for the office of President of the United States. Reagan won with 43,903,230 individual votes and 489 electoral votes. This was the largest electoral victory of any first-time presidential candidate in history. Reagan also became the oldest President to hold office at 69 years old. According to Stephen Wayne, "both Carter and Reagan were perceived negatively by a majority of the electorate."[5] However, many saw Reagan's campaign as one of optimism and viewed Carter's platform as very negative. The country faced low economic growth, high inflation and interest rates, and an energy crisis caused by oil prices as a byproduct of the Iranian revolution. This election was seen as a realignment of American politics and was the beginning of the "Reagan revolution."

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[4] Austin Ranney, ed., *The American Elections of 1980*, AEI Studies pg. 151 (Washington, D.C: American Enterprise Institute for Public Policy Research, 1981).
[5] Wayne, Stephen J. *The Road to the White House: The Politics of Presidential Elections*. 2. edition. New York/N.Y: St. Martin's Press, 1984.

The Evangelical Role

The Evangelical Christian voting bloc had a major impact on the outcome of the 1980 election. Their sheer voting strength, coupled with the development and spending of PACs and strategic mobilization of voters, lead to Ronald Reagan's decisive victory in 1980. This unified voting bloc has since become a powerful political force, influencing the election of numerous later presidents and impacting various policies and issues. Their impact on the 1980 election demonstrated that Evangelical Christians would be a major force to be reckoned with on the future American political landscape.

Voting Strength

During the Civil Rights Movement of the 1960s, evangelicals rallied in opposition to the advancement of social justice for African Americans by resisting the "growth of the federal government and legislation that furthered black rights" according to the Harvard Theological Review.[6] With the passing of the civil rights act, evangelicals saw that they had no common value set to rally around. So, they were largely inactive and dispersed for the next decade. According to a Gallup poll, by 1976, nearly 50 million Americans were evangelical Christians.[7] Comprising roughly one-third of the American adult population, evangelical Christians had become the largest religious voting base in American politics. After the 1960s, the question arose: where would this powerful voting bloc decide to act next?

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[6] Evans, Curtis J. "White Evangelical Protestant Responses to the Civil Rights Movement." *Harvard Theological Review* 102, no. 2 (April 2009): 245–73. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0017816009000765.
[7] Briggs, Kenneth. "Gallup Poll Finds New Evidence Of the Religious Character of U.S." *The New York Times*, September 12, 1976, sec. Archives. https://www.nytimes.com/1976/09/12/archives/gallup-poll-finds-new-evidence-of-the-religious-character-of-us.html.

The ideological unification of evangelicals was uncertain and swaying in the 1970s, with Carter being generally supported in his first election in 1976. Going into the election of 1980, it appeared his support from evangelicals would continue. George Gallup, the founder of Gallup Polls, had this to say in a September 1980 edition of the Washington Post:

> Although the presidential race is neck-and-neck between President Carter and Ronald Reagan, Carter is clearly the favorite among the fifth of the electorate who can be described as evangelicals, a group whose vote could be decisive in a close election.
>
> In a trial heat among the three leading presidential candidates, Carter receives the support of 52 percent of evangelicals who are registered to vote to 31 percent for Reagan and 6 percent for John B. Anderson, the independent.[8]

Although Carter had the strongest evangelical support going into the election, Reagan came out with an astounding advantage. A post-election poll conducted by researchers Jeffery L Brudney and Gary W Copeland found that evangelicals and fundamentalists alike overwhelmingly voted for Reagan.

TABLE 1

Political Views by Fundamentalist Religious Identification

	Fundamentalist	Nonfundamentalist	Highly Religious	Less Religious	Close to Evangelicals	Not Close to Evangelicals
Ideology	*Mean*	*Mean*	*Mean*	*Mean*	*Mean*	*Mean*
Own liberalism/conservatism	4.6*	4.3*	5.0*	4.2*	5.1*	4.3*
Evaluation of Carter liberalism/conservatism	3.8	3.7	3.9	3.7	3.3*	3.8*
Evaluation of Reagan liberalism/conservatism	5.1	5.2	5.0	5.2	5.3	5.3
Feeling Thermometer	*Mean*	*Mean*	*Mean*	*Mean*	*Mean*	*Mean*
Feeling for Carter	62.5*	54.7*	60.0*	55.5*	49.4*	56.4*
Feeling for Reagan	60.6*	56.2*	65.2*	55.6*	70.3*	56.1*
Electoral Behavior	*Percent*	*Percent*	*Percent*	*Percent*	*Percent*	*Percent*
Voted	64.8*	72.7*	78.3	70.4	83.1*	70.7*
Voted for Reagan	55.1	58.5	63.3	57.9	86.0*	54.9*

* Statistical significance at the .05 level, based on *t* tests or chi-square, where appropriate.

BRUDNEY, Jeffrey L, and Gary W COPELAND. "Evangelicals as a Political Force: Reagan and the 1980 Religious Vote." *Social Science Quarterly* 65, no. 4 (December 1, 1984): 1072.

[8] Gallup, George. "Carter Found the Clear Favorite Among Evangelicals." *Washington Post*, September 7, 1980.https://www.washingtonpost.com/archive/politics/1980/09/07/carter-found-the-clear-favorite-among-evangelicals/d14dd751-64a6-46ea-8fb1-4d878b46be0b/.

Moreover, 86% of polling respondents that classified themselves as "close to evangelicals" voted for Reagan (Table 1).[9] This was an astounding swing from pre-election polling. The power of the voting bloc had been exemplified in two back-to-back elections.

PAC Development and Spending

The raised importance of political action committees due to the FECA Campaign Legislature of 1971 was clear in the development of religious PACs in 1980. Since Reagan catered to the moral and political beliefs of evangelical Christians, big-name evangelical leaders saw that they could further their ideals through the Republican party. This led to the creation of many religious PACs that benefited both Republican candidates and evangelical leaders.

Jerry Falwell, an American pastor, televangelist, and conservative activist, founded the Moral Majority PAC. Falwell was motivated by his belief that "what's happened to America is that the wicked are bearing rule. We have to lead the nation back to the moral stance that made America great...we need to wield influence on those who govern us" and he certainly grew to wield that influence.[10]

With contentious issues like abortion, the Moral Majority PAC was able to fund large-scale slanderous attacks against Jimmy Carter and his campaign. Carter wrote in his autobiography that in the Fall of 1980, "a group headed by Jerry Falwell purchased $10 million in commercials on Southern radio & TV to brand me as a traitor to the South and no longer a Christian."[11] The $10 million dollars spent by the Moral Majority PAC was over one-third of the operating budget of both the Carter and Reagan campaigns.

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[9] BRUDNEY, Jeffrey L, and Gary W COPELAND. "Evangelicals as a Political Force: Reagan and the 1980 Religious Vote." *Social Science Quarterly* 65, no. 4 (December 1, 1984): 1072.
[10] Eileen Oginitz, "Evangelicals Seek Political Clout," Chicago Tribune, January 3, 1980
[11] Carter, Jimmy. *White House Diary*. 1st ed. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2010.

Through the creation of PACs and the ability to raise large sums of money, religious groups were able to gain unprecedented political power and sway elections. The Moral Majority PAC, founded by Jerry Falwell, is a prime example of this, as it was able to fund such a massive attack against Jimmy Carter's campaign in 1980. The power and impact that PACs had on the 1980 election raises questions about the influence of PACs and religious groups on the political process and the potential for the abuse of power by outside money in politics. The McCain Feingold legislation of 2002 later patched this loophole by limiting soft money's usefulness in political advertisements.[12] But, in 2010, both the FECA laws and the McCain Feingold act were overturned by the Supreme Court decision Citizens United vs. FEC.[13]

Mobilization of Voters

Mobilizing voters is the aim of every political campaign, political action committee, and electoral activist. The issues that bring voters to the polls are often smaller in the wide scheme of political debate. Rarely are political ads discussing a candidate's opinions on Keynesian or Monetarist economics or fiscal policy. More commonly they discuss dinner-table topics that have a direct impact on the life of the individual voter. Jerome L Himmleston discusses why social issues play such an integral role in voter mobilization:

> Because social issues have special significance for many of those most active in the conservative movement, they are disproportionately visible and contentious; thus they get disproportionate attention from politicians and the media. But even if they do not have a direct impact on the general public, they may have an indirect one: without influencing

[12] LII / Legal Information Institute. "Bipartisan Campaign Reform Act of 2002." Accessed December 16, 2022. https://www.law.cornell.edu/wex/bipartisan_campaign_reform_act_of_2002.
[13] FEC.gov. "Citizens United v. FEC." Accessed December 16, 2022. https://www.fec.gov/legal-resources/court-cases/citizens-united-v-fec/.

> how the average person votes, they may help mobilize the activists who get people out to vote and help shape who they vote for.[14]

So, when PACs like Jerry Falwell's "Moral Majority" rally around an issue like abortion, it is clearly important to their supporters and as such has a greater ability to draw people to the polls. It definitely worked. According to Randall E King's writing in the Journal of Church and State, Falwell's "moral majority" lobbying group was responsible for bringing two-thirds of the white evangelical vote to Ronald Reagan.[15] Moreover, the cause was extremely widespread thanks to PACs and Reagan's mobilization. For example, pro-life evangelicals leafleted church parking lots the Sunday before the 1980 election in order to get out the vote for the GOP.[16]

Reagan's Methods of Attracting Evangelicals

Ronald Reagan and his campaign are credited with effectively attracting and rallying voters around him. This is shown beyond just the evangelical crowd. By pivoting on issues and speaking to moral principles, evangelicals flocked to the polls in support of the GOP and Reagan. Reagan's popularity and ability to rally support were shown not just in his race but also in the 1980 congressional elections. Republicans gained 34 seats in the House of Representatives and flipped 12 seats in the Senate, granting the GOP control of the Senate for the first time since Dwight D Eisenhower.[17]

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[14] Himmelstein, Jerome L. *To the Right: The Transformation of American Conservatism*. Berkeley, Calif.: Univ. of California Press, 1992.
[15] KING, RANDALL E. "When Worlds Collide: Politics, Religion, and Media at the 1970 East Tennessee Billy Graham Crusade." *Journal of Church and State* 39, no. 2 (1997): 273–95.
[16] Busch, Andrew. *Reagan's Victory: The Presidential Election of 1980 and the Rise of the Right*. American Presidential Elections Series. Lawrence: University Press of Kansas, 2005.
[17] "Statistics of the Presidential and Congressional Election of November 4, 1980" (PDF). U.S. House of Reps, Office of the Clerk. Retrieved 16 December 2022.

Issue Pivoting

Reagan had every intention to be a popular candidate and was willing to shift his policy beliefs in favor of public opinion. For example, Robert S. Erikson and Kent L. Tedin write in their book "American Public Opinion" that although Ronald Reagan was a "strong proponent of a voluntary social security program" in the 1970s and early 1970s, he "dropped the issue when he ran for the presidency" because "polls showed a large portion of the public disagreed."[18]

In the case of evangelical voters, Reagan adopted every mainstream position of the bloc. Reagan took outspoken stances on reinstating prayer in school, opposing the Equal Rights Amendment, and becoming the figurehead of the pro-life cause. His lack of allegiance to a value set over his political career allowed him to follow public opinion and generate popularity. As the governor of California in 1967, Reagan passed legislation that increased access to abortion. The Therapeutic Abortion Act extended the number of circumstances where the procedure was permitted. As his presidential campaign got off the ground, Reagan leaned hard into the pro-life crowd. According to Donald Granberg and James Burlison of Family Planning Perspectives, his clearest declaration of his definitive pro-life stance was when he "expressed support for the Human Life Amendment, the antiabortion amendment most favored by the National Right to Life Committee (NRLC), the largest of the organized groups seeking to overturn the 1973 Supreme Court decisions."[19]

Speaking to Christian Morality

Reagan spoke loudly and clearly on most topics, but most notably on his religious beliefs. He spoke about faith, freedom, and family values in a way that resonated deeply with evangelical

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[18] Erikson, Robert S., and Kent L. Tedin. *American Public Opinion: Its Origins, Content, and Impact*. Tenth Edition. New York: Routledge, 2019.
[19] "The Abortion Issue in the 1980 Elections." *Family Planning Perspectives*, 2022.

Christians. His ability to effectively communicate his vision for a better America by means of protecting religious liberty and moral values was a key factor in his 1980 electoral victory.

Reagan and his campaign team made an immense effort to reach American evangelicals, they visited churches and conferences where they knew Reagan could easily talk the crowd into voting. For instance, Reagan's campaign accepted an invitation from a pastor's conference in Dallas, Texas. That conference also invited Jimmy Carter and John Anderson, but both declined because of the right-lean of the meeting. The following is an excerpt from "Rivalry and Reform" which emphasizes the help Reagan had in connecting with evangelicals.

> As roughly sixteen thousand conservative evangelical pastors and lay leaders filled Reunion Arena in Dallas, Robison and John Connally picked up Reagan at the airport to brief him before his address. During the ride, Robison explained that his evangelical gathering was officially nonpartisan and thus could not endorse Reagan. "I told him that . . . it would probably be wise if his opening comment would be, 'I know this is non-partisan, so you can't endorse me, but I want you to know that I endorse you,' " Robison recounts. "Oh he loved that. He wrote that down and said, 'That's great. I'm going to use it.'"[20]

This type of connection was exactly what brought voters out for Reagan on November 4th. Each of those 16,000 pastors had a story to tell the next Sunday, so Reagan effectively reached far more voters than saw him speak. Evangelicals felt that Reagan thought as they thought and would do as they wanted to be done, which was not true of Carter. Carter was popular among evangelicals during his first term because he was the first Southern Evangelical in the White House, even though he did not share all the policy beliefs of the evangelical base.[21]

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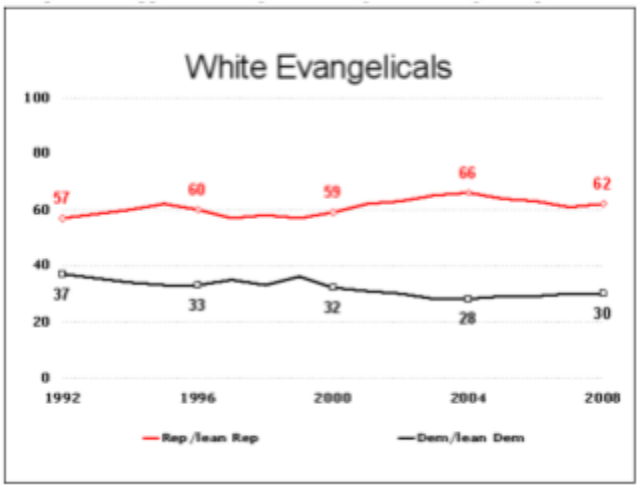
[20] Milkis, Sidney M., and Daniel J. Tichenor. *Rivalry and Reform: Presidents, Social Movements, and the Transformation of American Politics*. Chicago ; London: The University of Chicago Press, 2019.
[21] Balmer, Randall. "His Own Received Him Not: Jimmy Carter, First Evangelical President." Religion Dispatches, October 8, 2014. https://religiondispatches.org/his-own-received-him-not-jimmy-carter-first-evangelical-president/.

Reagan's connection to evangelicals only grew stronger over his two terms in office. In 1983 he was invited to speak at the National Association of Evangelicals and his introduction shows exactly how he was viewed by this new voting bloc: "The National Association of Evangelicals community, from coast to coast in our great land deeply appreciates and values his love for the truth of the Bible and his commitment to its great moral values, ladies and gentlemen the President of the United States, Ronald Reagan."[22]

The Lasting Implications of the Conservative Evangelical Bloc

Ronald Reagan's ability to connect and mobilize a large voting base was evident in his landslide re-election victory.[23] The continued cohesiveness of the evangelical right has been integral to the shaping of recent political events. In every election since 1980, evangelical Christians have overwhelmingly supported the republican presidential candidate (Table 2).[24]

Table 2



Donald Trump's victory in the 2016 Presidential election showed a continuance of the evangelical right as a political force. Trump's campaign had many parallels with Reagan's: shifting position on abortion

[22] *Vintage CTN - President Ronald Reagan 1983 National Association of Evangelicals*, 2017. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qdqk6QDDIPw.
[23] "United States Presidential Election of 1984 | United States Government | Britannica." Accessed December 17, 2022. https://www.britannica.com/event/United-States-presidential-election-of-1984.
[24] Green, John C. "Analyzing the Fall Campaign: Religion and the Presidential Election." *Pew Research Center's Religion & Public Life Project* (blog), September 9, 2008. https://www.pewresearch.org/religion/2008/09/09/analyzing-the-fall-campaign-religion-and-the-presidential-election/.

rights, pandaring to evangelical morality, and winning the now well-established evangelical block.[25]

The issue of abortion was largely nonpartisan before the election of 1980, and religious beliefs on the topic were far from stratified.[26] In rallying the religious right, Reagan made the issue of abortion a cornerstone issue of his candidacy and presidency.[27] The religious civil society groups that formed in support of Reagan did so in newfound opposition to the Roe vs. Wade Supreme Court Decision of 1973. The issue became heavily partisan, and by today in 2022, the ideological sorting has created a Democratic base of pro-choice advocates that back Roe and a Republican base of pro-life advocates that wanted to see the decision overturned.

Trump's nomination and victory in 2016 gave the religious right the opportunity to revert to a pre-Roe world. His appointment of three conservative justices to the Supreme Court created a conservative majority.[28] One third of the court was Trump appointed when the Dobbs v. Jackson case was decided, and the mission of evangelical conservatives had been accomplished in full.[29]

Today, in a post Roe v. Wade political landscape, we look back at the election of 1980 as the turning point for the religious right. It was Reagan who was able to rally evangelical voters into unified and ideologically homogeneous PACs. As a result, 50 years later, Jerry Falwell,

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[25] Husser, Jason. "Why Trump Is Reliant on White Evangelicals." *Brookings* (blog), April 6, 2020. https://www.brookings.edu/blog/fixgov/2020/04/06/why-trump-is-reliant-on-white-evangelicals/.
[26] Sullivan, Andy. "Explainer: How Abortion Became a Divisive Issue in U.S. Politics." *Reuters*, June 25, 2022, sec. United States. https://www.reuters.com/world/us/how-abortion-became-divisive-issue-us-politics-2022-06-24/.
[27] "The Abortion Issue in the 1980 Elections." *Family Planning Perspectives*, 2022.
[28] "U.S. Senate: Supreme Court Nominations (1789-Present)." Accessed December 17, 2022. https://www.senate.gov/legislative/nominations/SupremeCourtNominations1789present.htm.
[29] Oyez. "Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization." Accessed December 17, 2022. https://www.oyez.org/cases/2021/19-1392.

Ronald Reagan, and the Evangelical right got their wish in the reversal of the constitutional right to medical privacy.[30]

Conclusion

The election of 1980 between Ronald Reagan and Jimmy Carter gave way to the formation, unification, and mobilization of the largest and most powerful religious voting bloc in American history. Ronald Reagan's intentional pandering to his conservative Christian base swayed millions to not only hit the polls for him but to fun opposition attacks against his opponent Jimmy Carter. The creation of religious PACs, most notably Jerry Falwell's "Moral Majority" allowed for extra money in the political sphere beyond what was allowed by Reagan's own expenditure.

The ability of Reagan to cultivate such a widespread following allowed him to win the presidency and pass legislation that would implicate the lives of all Americans for decades to come. His theories of supply-side economics, conservative social values, anti-drug policies, and others have had wide-reaching effects.[31]

Today's American political landscape has been continually shaped by this religious faction that seems to never subside. There are other issues that seem to be at the front of the conservative evangelical cause in the current American political landscape: critical race theory,

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[30] Fritze, John. "Overturning Roe v. Wade a Triumph of Decadeslong Push by Conservative Legal Movement." USA TODAY. Accessed December 17, 2022. https://www.usatoday.com/story/news/politics/2022/07/05/supreme-court-roe-v-wade-abortion-history-federalist-society/7740097001/.

[31] "The Reagan Presidency | Ronald Reagan." Accessed December 17, 2022. https://www.reaganlibrary.gov/reagans/reagan-administration/reagan-presidency.

the sanctity of "traditional" marriage, and still prayer in schools.[32] [33] [34] With a base so interconnected and ideologically consistent, whatever issue is next on the docket will face widespread power in voting, mobilization, and ideological questioning by this now-weathered voting bloc. What issue will this base, connected by Reagan and motivated by Conservative figureheads, tackle next?

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[32] Kramer, Stephanie. "White Evangelicals More Likely than Other Christians to Say People Should Prioritize Marriage, Procreation." *Pew Research Center* (blog). Accessed December 17, 2022. https://www.pewresearch.org/fact-tank/2021/12/16/white-evangelicals-more-likely-than-other-christians-to-say-people-should-prioritize-marriage-procreation/.

[33] Tranby, Eric, and Douglas Hartmann. "Critical Whiteness Theories and the Evangelical 'Race Problem': Extending Emerson and Smith's 'Divided by Faith.'" *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 47, no. 3 (2008): 341–59. http://www.jstor.org/stable/20486928.

[34] Laats, Adam. "The Supreme Court Has Ushered In a New Era of Religion at School." The Atlantic, July 15, 2022. https://www.theatlantic.com/ideas/archive/2022/07/supreme-court-religion-schools-prayer-kennedy-carson/661365/.

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